



almost two years.

Only days ahead of the World Championship, the newly-elected ISSF board changed the format of the finals, but that didn't deter Mehuli Ghosh from scoring 634.5 in the qualification round of the 10m air rifle — unimaginable a few years ago — and eventually winning the bronze medal. A Paris quota was the icing on the cake. Shiva Narwal and Esha Singh won the 10m mixed team gold to become the only Indian world champions in an Olympic category in 2023.

The final countdown

This year would be all about reeling in the remaining Olympic quota places. The National Rifle Association of India already has 17 quotas as of writing, a new record, with Vijayveer Sidhu being the latest to pocket the second 25m rapid-fire pistol slot alongside Anish Bhanwala in the recently concluded Rifle and Pistol Asian Championship in Jakarta. In trap and skeet, India has so far managed to win only two of the maximum eight possible Olympic quota places.

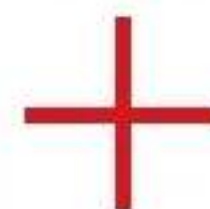
Incredible feat: Sift Kaur Samra won India's first individual gold medal at the Asian Games in Hangzhou, topping the women's 50m rifle 3 positions final with a new world record score of 469.6. A. M. FARUQUI

The country could very well fill up the vacant slots from two more competitions: the Asian Shotgun Championship in Kuwait between January 12-22 and April's final Olympic Qualification Championship in Rio (Rifle and Pistol) and Doha (Shotgun). While on paper, India can grab all 24 quotas, it will be a tall task.

Before the Paris 2024 entry deadline on July 8, the International Olympic Committee will also have allocated the final spots based on Universality Places and Qualification Ranking for the Olympic Games (QROG).

New selection policies

While quotas never belonged to the athlete except for those awarded through QROG, it used to all but confirm an Olympic ticket the last



Highlights of 2023

The country lapped up 22 medals, while breaking 18 records at the Hangzhou Asiad. The previous best showing was 14 medals at Doha 2006

Women

Sift Kaur Samra surpassed the individual world record in women's 50m rifle 3 positions at the Asian Games

Mehuli Ghosh shot 634.5 in 10m air rifle qualification at the World Championships. Won a bronze and an Olympic quota in the final

Esha Singh won four medals at the Asian Games. Ashi Chouksey bagged three

Men

Aishwary Pratap Singh Tomar won four medals at the Asian Games

Mixed

Esha Singh and **Shiva Narwal** became the only reigning World Champions in an Olympic category